Fate kindly placed him in the company of Sachin Tendulkar, who had been promoted as a symbol of national unity and resistance in the wake of the attacks. His call for the nation to come together had been replayed endlessly on TV. An impassioned address ended with the words: ‘I play for India. Now more than ever.’ On 99 and needing four to win, he steered Swanny’s delivery to the long leg boundary. The place went nuts.

We drew the second Test in cold and foggy conditions in the north of the country and flew home for Christmas Eve. It was not entirely the season of goodwill to all men. The personality clash between KP and Moores required a solution, though the captain was not the only player to doubt the coach. I had known Peter from his Academy days, loved his enthusiasm and responded to his intensity. Several others, including Straussy, felt his approach masked certain shortcomings.

Things were coming to a head as the New Year approached. I parked up near my home at the time, in the village of East Hanningfield in Essex, to take a call from Hugh Morris. With very little preamble he asked: ‘Who should go, KP or Moores?’ His tone suggested it was not his first conversation along those lines. It seemed a deceptively simple summary of a complicated situation.

Culture change in sport is rarely straightforward. This transition had to be placed in the perspective of Duncan Fletcher’s eight-year spell as England head coach, from 1999 to 2007. He was hugely influential, extremely successful, very dour. A hands-off coach, whom some believed gave senior players too much power, he was, in emotional terms, the antithesis of Moores.

I told Hugh that Peter was a very good coach who would respond to the lessons of his retention. I didn’t think KP had the temperament to remain as captain, though I stressed the importance of his playing presence. As it turned out, the fate of both men was sealed. Moores readjusted in county cricket and KP returned to the international ranks.

It had not been a tight ship. There was no common, overarching goal. Individual agendas led to inconsistency. As we approached the 2009 Ashes series, we craved an anchor point, something to hold on to. Andy Flower used statistics to back up his argument that we had fallen below the standards demanded and delivered by the Australians.

The group contained strong characters, very talented cricketers, once-in-a-generation players. Freddie was approaching the end of his career, but a